

Rare Impact Fund LOI Narrative

Program: Pathways to Purpose: Building Central Texas's Nonclinical Youth Mental Health Workforce

Organization: The Collaborative Advocate Foundation (TCAF)

Organizational Background and Capacity

The Collaborative Advocate Foundation (TCAF) is a veteran-founded, Black-led 501(c)(3) nonprofit based in Pflugerville, Texas focused on building workforce and health infrastructure for underserved communities. We operate ThriveUp Academy, a workforce ecosystem integrating training, implementation science, and real-time evaluation. Our model is anchored in RPLICE (CFIR 2.0 + RE-AIM) and executed through MAP-GAP cycles, enabling continuous 30-day performance improvement. Our team has demonstrated capacity in workforce pipeline design | community health worker training | culturally responsive curriculum | data-driven evaluation. We currently deliver workforce readiness programming with school and community partners, demonstrating readiness for immediate implementation and scale.

Nonclinical Mental Health Provider Experience

TCAF has a TX certified CHW instructor, Public health specialist, and psychologist and supports nonclinical providers through multiple platforms. Sankofa Health Network delivers community-based programming designed for CHWs | peer specialists | navigators focused on engagement and prevention. Our workforce readiness curriculum builds core competencies required for nonclinical roles | communication | teamwork | problem-solving. LifeBridge trains participants in benefits navigation | barrier identification | referral coordination. Speech Bridge ensures multilingual access, enabling providers to serve diverse populations effectively.

Program Description

TCAF proposes a two-year initiative to build a scalable nonclinical youth mental health workforce pipeline across Central Texas. Pipeline coverage includes Recruitment | Training | Placement | Upskilling | Retention.

Recruitment uses GIS-informed targeting (CDC | Census | SAMHSA) to identify high-need communities and prioritize individuals with lived experience and cultural alignment | Training is delivered through a phone-first platform including workforce readiness | Youth Mental Health First Aid | trauma-informed care | adolescent development with fidelity monitoring | Placement connects participants to schools | community organizations | youth-serving systems with supervised onboarding | Upskilling provides pathways into CHW certification | peer specialist roles | behavioral health careers | Retention includes cohort-based support | provider mental health access | continuous feedback loops.

Target population: young adults (18–30) from underserved communities with priority for lived experience | bilingual capacity | high Social Vulnerability Index areas.

Workforce Pipeline Need and Counterfactual

Central Texas faces increasing youth mental health demand with insufficient workforce capacity. Youth experience 3–6 month delays while schools and emergency departments absorb unmet need.

Current counterfactual (without intervention): no coordinated pipeline exists | workforce entry remains fragmented | licensed providers absorb preventable demand | individuals with lived experience remain underutilized | early-career burnout persists without structured support.

Without intervention, the system continues to rely on limited clinical capacity while failing to build scalable community-based support roles.

Youth Focus

Youth mental health requires developmentally and culturally specific approaches. The program integrates training in adolescent development | recruitment of near-peer providers | incorporation of youth-defined priorities into service delivery. This improves trust | engagement | and relevance of services.

Pipeline Connectivity

Entry occurs through school systems (Pflugerville ISD | Manor ISD) | workforce boards | targeted outreach in high-need communities. Post-program, participants transition into partner organizations with continued access to training | peer networks | career pathways through ThriveUp Academy. This ensures continuity from recruitment through long-term workforce participation.

Equity Strategy

Equity is embedded across all components: recruitment targeting high-SVI communities | culturally responsive curriculum | phone-first delivery | multilingual access | real-time disaggregated data by race | ethnicity | language | geography. This enables continuous identification and correction of disparities.

Youth Voice and Lived Experience Integration

Youth voice and lived experience are integrated through curriculum design input | recruitment prioritization | continuous feedback cycles every 30 days. This ensures program responsiveness and relevance.

Anticipated Outcomes and Impact :Over two years: 120–150 providers trained and placed | ≥70% placement rate | ≥65% 12-month retention | reduced service delays in partner sites | increased youth engagement in community-based support. The model establishes a replicable pipeline for regional scale.

Funding Request

\$350,000 over 2 years | Participant support \$85,000 | Training \$70,000 | Staff \$100,000 | Technology \$35,000 | Evaluation \$25,000 | Indirect \$35,000

Partnerships

Pflugerville ISD | Integral Care | Lone Star Circle of Care | NAMI Central Texas | Hargrave Innovative Solutions | Universal Spectrum| A consortium of identified churches and councilmembers.